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HANIF KUREISHI

MY SON, THE FANATIC

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Hanif Kureishi – My son, the fanatic

Assignments

1. Summarize how some young Muslims are attracted by a fundamentalist interpretation of Islam.
2. Analyze Kureishi's main point and how he structures his text in order to put it forth.
3. Hanif Kureishi claims that young people are often focused on their own pleasure and enjoyment. Discuss this claim considering your own living conditions as well as the short story "My Son the Fanatic".

1. Summarize

In excerpt "The Road Exactly", published 1997, Hanif Kureishi explores why some young British Muslims, despite being raised in a secular society, are drawn to a strict and authoritarian version of Islam. He questions why they reject the pleasures of Western life—such as sex, music, and independence—and whether their embrace of religious discipline is a form of rebellion or a reaction to societal instability.

Kureishi suggests that this turn to fundamentalism is linked to a broader "crisis of authority" in modern society. When traditional hierarchies break down, some people seek strict religious structures to provide certainty and stability. He observes that these young Muslims willingly submit to religious figures and a punishing vision of God, despite their intelligence and education.

Ultimately, Kureishi argues that their religious conservatism is not just about faith but also about responding to feelings of alienation and disillusionment. When individuals feel excluded from mainstream society, they may, in turn, reject that society by embracing an alternative system that promises structure and meaning.

2. Analyze

Hanif Kureishi's introduction, "The Road Exactly," explores the paradox of young Muslims in Britain who, despite growing up in a secular society, embrace a strict, authoritarian interpretation of Islam. His main point is to question why these individuals choose to reject the pleasures of Western society, such as sex, music, and personal autonomy, in favor of religious constraints. He views this rejection as a response to a broader "crisis of authority" and a reaction to feelings of exclusion, discrimination, and disillusionment with the promises of the West.

Kureishi opens with his perplexity at why young people raised in a secular society would turn to a restrictive belief system. He highlights the contradiction between their desire for pleasure and their decision to deny it, questioning whether this choice is a form of rebellion or an attempt to create order in an over-sexualized yet spiritually empty society.

He delves into the strict nature of the Islam embraced by these young people, emphasizing their willingness to surrender personal freedom to religious figures (Maulvis) and a retributive God. He sees this as a reaction to a broader societal instability—when old hierarchies collapse, people tend to seek rigid authority structures.

Kureishi suggests that these young Muslims use religious discipline to counteract the overwhelming choices and temptations of Western society. Islam, in this context, becomes a way to provide stability, self-discipline, and an identity that resists moral corruption.

The historical and social context is crucial to Kureishi's argument. He explains that the children and grandchildren of immigrants face persistent racism, economic disadvantage, and exclusion in Britain. This disillusionment fuels their attraction to an alternative system that offers belonging and meaning, even if it means rejecting Western ideals.

The final section ties these ideas together, arguing that since young Muslims feel excluded from British society, they may, in turn, choose to exclude others by embracing a strict religious identity. The West, for many, has failed to deliver on its promises of inclusion and prosperity, leading some to find solace in religious conservatism.

Kureishi's main point is that the turn to religious fundamentalism among young British Muslims is not merely about faith but is deeply tied to identity, exclusion, and the search for authority in a chaotic world. He presents this argument through a combination of personal reflection, rhetorical questioning, and historical context, making the case that religious extremism is, in part, a response to societal failures rather than purely a theological choice.